



A THERAPIST'S GUIDE

STOP TRYING TO “READ” PEOPLE

Getting better information before you decide what something means.



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Dating advice has taught us to interpret everything.

He didn't text back?	He's not interested.
He texts too much?	Love bombing.
He doesn't open up?	Emotionally unavailable.
He opens up too quickly?	Trauma dumping.
He plans dates?	He's intentional.
He doesn't plan far enough ahead?	You're not a priority.

At some point, dating became less about getting to know people and more about trying to decode every move they make.

And listen—sometimes the thing you noticed really does mean something. But it does not mean the same thing in every situation with every person. That's the part a lot of dating advice leaves out.

You don't know this person yet. You don't know their habits, their communication style, how they handle stress or conflict, or whether Tuesday was unusual or exactly what they do every Tuesday.

You're still learning. That is what dating is supposed to give you the chance to do.

This guide will help you stop guessing, slow down the story in your head, and get better at answering one very important question:

What do I actually know?

First Things First: Are Y'all Actually Dating?

We use the word *dating* very loosely. "I went on a date." "We've been on a few dates." "I'm dating him." "We're dating." Those are not always the same thing.

Going on a date is an event. You agreed to spend time together. Maybe the conversation was amazing, maybe there was chemistry, maybe you left thinking: *okayyyy, I like this one*. Great—you went on a date. That does not automatically mean you are now in a dating relationship with this person.

And this matters, because our expectations can move faster than the actual connection. You have one really good date and by Monday you're wondering: Why hasn't he called? Why is she still on the app? Are they seeing other people? Where is this going?

Ma'am. Y'all had tacos Thursday. Let's gather a little more information.

THE DISTINCTION	
A date	is an experience.
Dating	is an ongoing connection—built by two people who keep choosing to participate, talk again, make another plan, and learn about each other.
Commitment	is an agreement about what the relationship is. It doesn't have to happen on the same timeline as dating.

Interest does not automatically create a relationship. Neither does chemistry, sex, talking every day, or a really good first date. Those things may tell you something is developing—but you still need information.

Watch the Expectations You Add Too Early

Sometimes we start expecting relationship-level behavior from a connection that has not become a relationship. You may start expecting: daily texts, regular calls, weekend plans, updates on where they are, priority over other plans, access to their personal life, emotional support, exclusivity, an explanation every time they're unavailable.

But ask yourself: *did we actually establish that—or did I start expecting it because I like them?* That's worth checking.

This doesn't mean you accept anything just because the relationship is new. Basic respect is still basic respect. Consent still matters. Your boundaries still matter. Honesty still matters. You're allowed to decide after one date: *nope, not for me.*

The difference is between having standards for how you allow people to treat you, and placing expectations on a relationship the two of you have never actually created. And this goes both ways—you don't owe someone girlfriend-level access because they bought you dinner, either.

Now, About All This “Reading” People...

Being smart does not make you immune to assumptions. Sometimes it just makes you really good at building a convincing argument for the assumption you already made.

You noticed one thing. Your brain connected it to another thing. Then another. Now you have exhibits A through F, and your best friend is on FaceTime serving as co-counsel. Meanwhile: you still might not know what actually happened.

READING THEM	LEARNING THEM
<i>“He didn't respond all day. He's pulling away.”</i> <i>“She was quieter tonight. I must have done something.”</i> <i>“He says he's busy, but I think he's really afraid of commitment.”</i>	<i>“He didn't text me back today. I don't know why yet.”</i> <i>“She seemed quieter tonight. I can ask if something was going on.”</i> <i>“He told me he doesn't want a relationship. I don't need to create a secret meaning behind that.”</i>

You took something you observed and added an explanation. That explanation may be right—it may also be completely wrong. So before you promote your interpretation to a fact, slow it down. You're not ignoring what happens; you're paying attention without making up the missing information. That is a skill, and you can practice it.

Before You Decide What Something Means, Ask These 5 Questions

01	02	03	04	05
What actually happened?	What did I make it mean?	What else could be true?	Can I just ask?	What keeps happening?

1. What Actually Happened?

Start with the facts. Ask yourself: what would a camera have seen?

NOT: "He ignored me."

TRY: *"I texted him Monday afternoon. He responded Tuesday morning."*

NOT: "She doesn't respect my time."

TRY: *"She canceled our plans two hours before we were supposed to meet."*

NOT: "He's love bombing me."

TRY: *"He has texted me throughout the day every day since we met, and planned three dates this week."*

You can decide what something means later. First, describe what happened.

2. What Did I Make It Mean?

Now look at the story your mind added. For example—**what happened:** they haven't asked to see me again. **What I made it mean:** they're not interested. Could that be true? Absolutely. Do you know that yet? Maybe not.

Ask yourself: What conclusion did I jump to? What motive did I give them? What am I treating like a fact even though nobody told me that? Am I making this mean something positive because I like them—or negative because I'm afraid of getting hurt? Am I reacting to this person, or does this remind me of somebody else?

You're not trying to talk yourself out of your instincts. You're checking whether you have information or an interpretation. There is a difference.

3. What Else Could Be True?

Someone doesn't respond to your text for several hours. You might think: *they're losing interest*. Maybe. But they could also be working, busy, or may have simply forgotten to respond—or they communicate differently than you do. Or yes, they may not be that interested.

The goal isn't to invent ten excuses for somebody—please don't use this to become the defense attorney for foolishness. The goal is to remember your first explanation is not automatically the only one. If there's another reasonable possibility, you may need more information. If there isn't, that tells you something too.

4. Can I Just Ask?

Sometimes we do hours of emotional algebra when a simple question would help.

NOT: "He said he's busy. What do you think that means?"

TRY: *"When you say you're busy right now, what does that mean for dating?"*

NOT: "She hasn't been talking as much. I think she's pulling away."

TRY: *"I noticed we haven't talked as much this week. Has anything changed?"*

NOT: "I have no idea what we're doing."

TRY: *"How are you thinking about what we're doing right now?"*

Asking doesn't guarantee honesty—people can lie, avoid questions, or tell you what they think you want to hear. Which is why you're not only listening to the answer. You're paying attention to the response: do they answer, avoid it, get defensive, change the subject, or later match it with behavior? That is information too.

5. What Keeps Happening?

One moment gives you information. Repeated behavior gives you more. Someone being late once is one thing; being late almost every time is different information. One amazing date, one disagreement, one apology, one deep conversation—none of it tells you everything about someone's character. This is one reason time matters.

Pay attention to: do their words and actions usually match? Do they follow through? Does the same issue keep coming up? What happens when things don't go their way, when you say no, when you disagree, when you need clarification? Does confusing behavior become clearer with more information?

You don't need to decode every move. You need to notice what keeps happening.

But Please Don't Turn "I Need More Information" Into an Excuse

Sometimes you already have information. You just don't like what it tells you.

If somebody says “I’m not looking for anything serious,” that is information. You do not need a five-person panel to determine whether he secretly means *“unless the perfect woman changes my mind.”* He said what he said.

If someone regularly cancels plans and rarely reschedules—information. If someone tells you they can’t give you what you’re looking for—information. If someone keeps crossing a boundary you clearly stated—information. If what they say repeatedly doesn’t match what they do—information.

Discernment is not staying confused forever. Sometimes you need more information. Sometimes you have enough. The skill is learning the difference.

And No, You Don't Have to Wait for a “Pattern” to Protect Yourself

Looking for patterns does not mean you have to let someone hurt you five times before you’re allowed to respond. One experience can be enough to say: *I didn't like that. That crossed a line for me. I want to slow this down. That doesn't work for me. I'm not interested in continuing this.*

Patterns help you understand someone over time. They are not a requirement for having boundaries.

Let's Practice

The situation: You went on a great date Saturday. The conversation was good, there was chemistry, they told you they had a great time. It's now Wednesday. They've texted you a little, but haven't asked to see you again. Before you call the group chat—let's work through it.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED?

Write only what you know.

WHAT DID I MAKE IT MEAN?

What conclusion did you immediately reach?

WHAT ELSE COULD BE TRUE?

One or two other reasonable explanations.

CAN I ASK SOMETHING?

A question that would help you get more information.

WHAT KEEPS HAPPENING?

Do you even have a pattern yet?

WHAT DO I STILL NOT KNOW?



Now Use Your Own Situation

Think about the person currently taking up entirely too much space in your mental tabs.

What happened?

1 · WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED?

2 · WHAT DID I MAKE IT MEAN?

3 · WHAT ELSE COULD BE TRUE?

4 · WHAT COULD I ASK?

5 · WHAT KEEPS HAPPENING?

WHAT DO I STILL NOT KNOW?

Fact or Story?

A quick check for anytime you catch yourself spiraling.

Fact	Story
What did I actually see?	What do I think it means?
What did they actually say?	What do I think they "really" meant?
What did they actually do?	What motive am I giving them?
What has happened more than once?	What am I predicting will happen next?
What have we actually agreed to?	What relationship expectation have I added that we never discussed?

Your story might eventually turn out to be right. But right now, ask: *do I know this, or do I think this?* That one question can clean up a whole lot.

The Internet Cannot Tell You What This Particular Person Means

General dating advice can be useful. Patterns matter. Research matters. Healthy relationship skills matter. But no Instagram Reel can tell you exactly why the person you went on two dates with did something Tuesday afternoon. That requires context.

Dating advice gets dangerous when "this can mean" becomes "this always means." People are not formulas. The same behavior can happen for different reasons. That doesn't mean you ignore behavior—it means you gather enough information before deciding what it tells you.

You are not trying to become impossible to fool. You cannot guarantee that nobody will ever lie to you, disappoint you, reject you, or change their mind. Dating does not come with that guarantee. The goal is to get better at noticing what's happening, asking questions, recognizing patterns, using the information you receive, and trusting yourself to respond when something doesn't work for you.

Things You Can Stop Doing

Diagnose someone you just met.	Search for hidden meaning in every text.
Ask six people what one person "really meant."	Treat one great date like proof of a future.
Turn one awkward moment into a whole personality.	Explain away behavior because you really like them.
Assume every anxious feeling is intuition.	Assume every good feeling is compatibility.

Treat attention like commitment.

Create expectations nobody agreed to.

Guess what someone means when you can ask.

Keep asking questions when their behavior has already answered you.

Your job is not to solve the person. Your job is to learn enough to make decisions about your own participation.

Before You Try to “Read” Them...

Come back to these five questions:

1. **What happened?** — What do I actually know?
2. **What did I make it mean?** — What story did I add?
3. **What else could be true?** — Am I missing another reasonable explanation?
4. **What can I ask?** — Can I get more information instead of guessing?
5. **What keeps happening?** — What are their words and actions showing me over time?

And then ask—not what do I hope, not what do I fear, not what did TikTok say, not what does my friend who hated him from day one think—just: **what do I actually know about the person and connection in front of me today?**

You Are Allowed to Not Know Yet

One of the hardest parts of dating is not knowing. You like somebody. You want to know where it's going, how they feel, if this is going to work. And sometimes you simply don't have enough information yet.

That is not always a problem that needs to be solved. Sometimes that's just where you are in the process. You do not have to decide someone's entire character after two dates, or know whether somebody is your future spouse before you know their middle name. You also don't have to stay around indefinitely waiting for clarity that never comes.

Pay attention. Ask. Learn. Decide when there is enough information to decide. That is dating with your eyes open.

ABOUT THE RELATIONSHIP LIFE CYCLE™

Relationships don't start at commitment. There is a whole process of learning that happens before two people decide what they want to build together. The Relationship Life Cycle™ calls this phase **Exploration**—where you're learning who this person is, how you interact, what happens when things are easy and when they're not, and what you're noticing about yourself.

The goal is not to become better at getting chosen. The goal is to become better at using the information available to you—because you are making choices too.

Want to see how you currently show up in relationships?

Take the Free Relationship Life Cycle™ Snapshot

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